

THE DIRECTORY: THE SWORD OF DAMOCLES

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Dedicated to
The trip to Yosemite that sparked this book.
The people at Summer Moon for the space to write.
Cody Dzurizin for listening to all the versions of the Directory that has,
does, and will one day exist.
And to the lives of all the authors who gave me the courage to try my
hand at being an author one more time.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Distrust everything I say. I am telling the truth
— *Ursula Le Guin, The Left Hand of Darkness*

Shevirat HaKelim, or *The Breaking of the Vessels*, is a concept from Jewish mysticism taught by Rabbi Isaac Luria. The teaching promotes the idea that when the world was made, God's infinity was too great to be contained, and creation shattered into broken vessels. The world that we know is made up of these broken vessels, each of them containing a spark of God trapped inside.

This work of art is a testimony to those broken vessels filled with sparks of God and humanity's purpose. We were made to find those sparks in our everyday world, through kindness, art, justice, love, and spiritual awareness. I believe our purpose is to bring them back together. So does Trajan, and he tries so hard.

Many months before I started writing what would become the sequel to this book, the original concept of this series was about a boy who held no potential. I asked, what if he contemplates ending his life, but a duo of aliens approach him in a place called the Aeternum. They offer him a future, one where he would ultimately betray everyone he loved without realizing it. You'll probably know who this boy is if you make it far enough in the series, or maybe you won't, because this series is littered with boys who betray those they love.

The story evolved about ten or more times. It became a book, then a screenplay. I merged the various versions of them into another movie. I hated it, so I wrote another screenplay, which I struggled with. During that time, I kept trying to convince myself over and over again that screenplays were the way to go. People watch movies. No one reads like we used to.

I had finished a few screenplays, never a full length feature, but I had finished some. I had never finished writing a novel before. Funny enough, that's how I started writing when I was a kid. I wrote plots that were extremely similar to the books I was reading at the time, but I never did finish them. Then again, I've never believed in a story I've written as much as I believe in this one. I knew this story was supposed to be a book when I sat down and started describing how much Juno hated the Praetorium, a place you'll come to know in due time. I had never written from a woman's perspective, but it flowed from me like nothing ever had.

All that to say, I learned a lot about science fiction while making this story. I thought it was the cool genre that was defined by things like space operas with Star Wars, Dune, and Prometheus (the Alien series at large). It was a place where clones took the place of soldiers, and hyperspace lanes were the seas of the cosmos. I grew up playing games like Supreme Commander, Stellaris, Space Engineers, RimWorld, Halo, and Dyson Sphere Program. To me, sci-fi had to be big and grand or else you couldn't call it that at all.

As I was writing and delving into more and more sci-fi, I first learned that I preferred the genre over mass-marketed modern YA fiction, and secondly, that sci-fi was not a genre but a lens. One does not write sci-fi. It's more like you write a drama that happens to be in space. You write a tragedy or a comedy, or a dramedy that takes place thousands of years in the future. I could write a love story in space that also happened to deal with narcissistic rulers and religions governed by machines of war. The genre, just like any other, is a vessel in which to explore a story. It is a way to distance ourselves from talking about the present by instead talking about a future that mirrors certain aspects of how we live today.

The most important aspect of the genre that I learned was when I read Ursula K. Le Guin's great lesson: that words have a sound. I could not help but hear the sound her words made in the way she strung them together when I read her author's note to *The Left Hand of Darkness*. I heard the sound of Herbert's words when I read them in *Dune*, *Dune Messiah*, and *Children of Dune*. Veering from sci-fi, I heard the longest sound I'd ever heard when I read Andre Aciman's chapterless *Enigma Variations*. I hope you understand what that means, and that you hear the sound of my words.

I think about that boy a lot, the one who had tried to end his life because he didn't have a purpose. His society took an innocent youth and gave him expectations for him to live up to. They promised that they would give him the ideal life if he lived up to them. He quickly came to

discover that society was not going to follow through with its end of the bargain because of who he was, and so he turned to God instead. Things weren't much better with God. He failed him time and time again, but tried so desperately to tell others about him. He always found himself choosing his flesh over his father and was thoroughly disgusted with himself. But the question at large was, why was he disgusted with himself? Who had set up those unrealistic expectations? He was bound to fail, no matter how hard he tried.

I think about how that boy was a symbol of me at that point in my life. How I felt so insecure in my place in the world. Writing was all I had ever wanted to do, but I instead went to college and took a job I didn't want that drained me and kept me from doing the thing I was put on this Earth to do. I think he sometimes still is a representation of me. Perhaps all of the Vysarian boys are a blurry reflection of me. Or maybe my art is just a product of this world. A place to remember all the things that have happened to me and all the things that haven't. I'd be terrified to have my animites erased, so just in case I've written them all down here.

Writing this story has not secured my place in humanity, but it has come to help me extrapolate things. While I crafted this work of fiction, I also observed the real world harder than I ever had. I looked at athletes, politicians, my religion, friends, parents, boys that I had loved. I looked at influencers, celebrities, emperors, and empires. I thought about the country I was born into and

the privilege I had to even be a writer: to be able to consume a cup of coffee with creamer each time I sat down and wrote.

I cannot tell the future, but I do believe that we are a species where, eventually, everything grand and large will fade into existence. It's not because we're forgetful or that selfish (although at times we are), but it's because we all deserve the right to be human and to be remembered for the things we do for at least a fraction in the history of the cosmos and no more. The world has to make space for the rest of us who haven't gotten a chance to live yet. For the generations of humanity yet to be born.

I wonder if the world will ever reach the year when this story takes place. I wonder if my story will still be around, if it will have made an impact, or if it will have made people think critically about religion, identity, choice, and purpose. I think about all the classics I have read and wonder if my work will become a classic. If it will inspire, train, and teach hundreds of generations to come. I wonder if it will do its job. If it will teach at least one person something about life. If it will give them just a bit more meaning, a reason to wake up. I don't expect to be remembered forever or even remembered tomorrow, but I would be happy to give up my place in the history of the world if it means someone else gathers the courage to share the story that changed them.

But none of that matters because I know this book has achieved its purpose. I do not care if it makes people think. It made me think. It gave me a reason to wake up on so

many days when I would have rather not existed, but I had a story to tell, and I told it. It made me elated some days and cry on others. It was worth every word.

Throughout all the many versions and forms The Directory Series has taken, it has been and always will be about experiencing religion as a human at its core. It is about a boy who fears that he is growing up in a world where his love isn't accepted and that he might never find someone who could change the rules. It is about his son, who comes to realize that his father, the same one who was denied love, is incapable of loving him. The series is also about boys who cling to their faith because it's the only thing that won't forsake them, yet it's the thing that imprisons them in their minds. Lastly, it's about the dangers of putting too much at stake in the words written by men.

Speaking of words written by men, I wrote this story because it is true, as fictitious as it might be. My suggestion is to believe nothing that this book says, but listen to every sound it makes. Understand that the spaces it longs for do not yet exist, but one day they will. The people in power have never been born, but their essence has been and is still among us. They are very real, and they should be feared and their lies fought against. The book that these powerful people believe in has never flourished, but the raw faith that man-made religions exploit lives in each of us. Lastly, the institutions that perpetuate systemic discrimination look nothing like ours, but neither did the ones a hundred years ago; they simply changed hands and

names.

To reiterate Le Guin's thoughts once more, "I talk about god; I am an atheist. But I am an artist too, and therefore a liar. Distrust everything I say. I am telling the truth."

THE VANITY FAIR
*VANITY AT THE FAIR. VYSARIANS DEAD AT LAST.
DIRECTORIES DESTROYED. WHAT NEXT?*

“Because there have been so many rumors and speculation, let me tell you the story. The whole story. According to The Directory, the deaths occurred at the twenty-third hour— the direct result of the youngest son.”

The Vanity Fair, Jericho Jaroh

Millions craned their necks, desperate to catch a glimpse of the Omegas. The elite. Those entitled to attend Vanity Fair, an entire week dedicated to truth and the power of films. How lucky they were. How lucky it was for them to be in there, amongst all that talent, all that youth and grandeur, all that power. The power to persuade, to buy, to influence, to change. And did they use that power appropriately? Of course not. How would they keep their power if they did?

The Omegas were the first of the gods to walk the red carpet. The producers, directors, screenwriters. The upper echelon of the newly resuscitated film society and their beautiful porcelain families. They held their heads high like they had been taught to do so at birth. They didn't bother to look down on those who called after them, the brothers and sisters who had immigrated from Earth and were sorely enamored with them.

Those from Earth knew their kind well now. They knew to look upon them with awe. They had become the focal

point of what was left of society. Their wishes had become the desires of all, a never ending bout of milk and honey that the common folk suckled on from Monday to Friday to get them through the week. Their fits of passion and persuasion were the perfect topical conversations for Saturday lunches for those too dull to talk about anything interesting in their lives. Their most despicable secrets traveled throughout the universe and found a seat in the church pews every Sunday, reminding all those abroad that even gods committed sins when placed among men.

The Omegas' dresses flowed, and their suits parted open in the breeze of the faux wind. They soaked up every bit of attention they could garner and showed every bit of skin they could find. This is what made them mighty, the fact that people paid them mind, that people clamored to see them still after everything had happened. This night is what they longed for. It's why, even after all this time, they had chosen to go on living. The Fair was an excuse for them to show the universe the standard for beauty, to set the threshold for what it truly meant to look like for one to have money, and to remind the others who ruled the universe now that the Vysarians were gone.

The players arrived next, several minutes late behind the Omegas. They were dressed to the nines in absurd things, gowns and suits that cost them a small fortune, though nothing they hadn't made off of their royalties. It had barely made a dent in their accounts. The players had spent all day dressing and brunching, brunch before the dress, during, and after. Their bellies were filled with

butterflies swimming in lakes of mimosa and other nox. Their hearts were beating with blue hopes of winning. Their psyches were high, and their minds were fuzzy, all of them filled to the brim with the fog of smoking too much liquor. They stumbled and smiled.

Smile, wave, stumble, laugh it off, smile some more, answer a question, get pulled away for a photo, be asked a question during said photo, grab a glass, and then, with drink still in hand, be promptly launched into a group photo with other players that they despised. Down the drink, smile, flash, return the glass, shake a hand. Never mind that— germs were far too dirty— so instead, tilt the head slightly, then continue into the Atrium, for the night was set to begin. The sun shone brightly down on the ring as it disappeared beneath the dome. It was only four in the afternoon.

“Jesus, Mary, and Joseph,” Augustus Dragnoian’s voice echoed around the rings from the grand carpet. “Where have they been hiding you? You come out with the greatest movie in all of human history, and then you disappear from the face of the universe.”

Viola clung to Augustus’s wrists. She shrieked in a high pitch artificial voice to solidify the persona she had created for the masses. “I miss you. You have no idea how happy I am to see you.” She wiped a tear from just underneath her eye.

“Oh darling, I’ve missed you too. What are you wearing? Please, go on. Right there, into the microphone.”

“The shoes are Leopold’s—”

Augustus cut her off. "Do tell Viola, you're at Vanity Fair as a nominee for best actress, and you're up for a Jaroh. The very first one. When you woke up this morning, what was the first thing you thought of?"

"Well, I... I don't know Augusts. I just felt so, so, so deeply grateful. I'm so honored to be here. I've come a very long way from Flagstaff, you know. This wasn't something I ever dreamt of, not even in my wildest dreams. "

"It wasn't in The Directory?"

Viola shot Augustus a wild look as he had spoken something blasphemous.

"No! I don't subscribe— I mean, sure, I read what had been deciphered while we were filming. I mean, I had to—you understand that. The true gift of my life was playing Juno, so this part, being here for a Jaroh, well, I don't even know if I let my mind go that far."

"You know, you don't expect this type of thing while you're doing the work. The work was so important, you understand that, don't you? I didn't have time to think about things like this. Hell, we didn't even know a thing like this was going to exist! Every single day that I got to do the work was the most gratifying gift. This is a surreal acknowledgment, like a cherry on top, especially to be included among so many players that I love so much."

"Who's come up to you so far tonight and told you that they just loved your performance?"

Viola turned and tossed her hair over her shoulder, sending a look his way as if to scold him for making her

choose.

"Oh my goodness, just so many people. I mean, everyone has been so kind. I can't pick one person. You can't make me—I won't. It just truly feels like a big sleepaway camp where I get to see the most famous people on a random Sunday night, and it's so lovely and delightful. I'm such a huge fan of everyone, and I will miss them all.

"What was your favorite part about making this feature?"

"I enjoyed delving into the history. Working my way through the Old Directories. Reveling in the backstories. Juno was a real badass bitch in the end, and I envy her for that. Truly, I do."

"What's the next step?"

"The next step is... the next step." Viola laughed nervously. "They've done the memory erasure thing to me at the clinic, or so they told me. You know the one."

"Yes, I know the one. The animite skimming. Better than becoming an animus."

"Oh, I don't think they're all bad," Viola suggested innocently.

"But if you could remember, if you could struggle for just a second to know, what would you tell me?"

"You know what," she said, pressing a slim finger to her thin lip, "I'll have to go back to the clinic and see if they can restore the animite. I'll have to see if they can find it." Viola tried stepping away. "I'm sure it's somewhere," she said with squinted eyes and a fake smile.

"Well, are you coming out with something else soon?"

"Augustus, I'm not allowed to use that word. Soon means ten days or less where I'm from."

"So not less than ten days."

"I'm not going to use that word today." She came back to him, flustered and funny. "Oh, what are you doing? I love you, you're so naughty!" She poked and prodded at him.

"Just give me a date. A hint. I won't tell anyone," he said in a seductive tone.

"Keep your eyes peeled."

"Ok, you're right. I'm sorry, I didn't even hear what you said— who are you wearing?"

"Because I didn't." She pouted, then, "As I was saying, the shoes are Leopold's. The dress is Hurleighy, custom by Mertius Mark."

"Can you do a little spin?"

Viola obliged him and spun. Her gown furled up in the wind. "I missed you. This was so fun."

"Do you have a speech prepared?"

"No, are you crazy? Wait, should I?"

"You're one of the few people nominated for the Jaroh! You know that. You do know that, right?"

"I know, but... You know when you're running around the ring, you're doing your little jog that you do to keep up your figure, and you think *what if*, but you know that would never happen, so I thought what's the point of even coming up with a speech?"

"I, for one, look forward to you winning tonight. And

I'm looking forward to you having to come up with an impromptu speech."

"If I win, then you can come up and give my speech for me." Viola was pulled away by pleas from the crowd for photos and niceties. She sailed off, singing for them in a high headspace known only to the likes of her and her alone. They begged her for more, and she graced them like a goddess.

"I love you, Augustus. This really has been so fun. Don't be such a stranger, please," she said with a dashing wave of her tiny, fragile hands.

"Of course, my love. Of course." Augustus looked at the camera, dead center, and said with full confidence. "God, I hope that girl wins."

The afternoon wore on as the atmosphere cooled itself down to a temperature that the spectators found exceedingly pleasant. It was no secret that many of them had spent what little savings they had to get here tonight. They took everything in as much as they could, for it had cost them their life.

"And how will they get back?" Augustus asked a Delta who had worked on one of the films as an assistant. The two of them had run out of things to talk about.

"They won't. No one's going back to that hellhole."

"I suppose they might play an extra in the next film then."

"For the sake of their lives, I hope not. The Vysarians shed a lot of blood, and between you and me, Jericho demands nothing short of realism in its totality."

It was strange to think the Vysarians were finally gone. A family full of lost boys. They had tried to turn the universe on its head a million times in a vicious vow to fix the mistakes of their fathers. Each son was more relentless than the last. They pressed their agendas onto people and relentlessly waged wars across the universe in hopes of putting it back together again. And for what? They had gained nothing. As the first Vysarian had said, "Vanity of vanities. All was vanity."

What would life be like now that they were gone? The Vysarians. The Vanguard. The sleepwalkers. All of the copies of the heretical Directory had been burned. The only thing that remained where the animus on Earth. Life had the chance to return to normal, at least on the ring, but what was normal now? Who would define it? Who would usher in this new era? Was there anyone left to fill the vacuum that had been left behind?

People feared the notion of even trying to answer the question, and so, uncertain of where they were headed, they turned the future over to the only man who had been close to the family. The people set aside their differences and let Jericho Jaroh convene his Vanity Fair just before his twenty-eighth birthday.

He challenged them to ask *what if* and to lean into the magic of storytelling. He hoped that from their creativity, a new path might spring forth, one laden with hope for humanity. This time, society came together with a new type of fervor and hope because there weren't any Vysarians left to ruin what could be a good thing.

The trip to the Fair discouraged Jericho. He sank into a dark depression. With his birthday so close, he was due for a new sleeve, but the Fair couldn't wait. During the trip, he woke every morning to the same habits. He checked his eyes. Still white. His nails were still strong. No lesions on his skin. No thoughts of murder. No inclination to rage—yet. Now, when he arrived, it might be a different story.

That fact did worry him. If the filmmakers and players managed to rile him up, the people from Earth might use his vessel against him to discredit him. As he stared out of the Commodore past the newly minted spiraling ring of Atlas, into the darkest reaches of space, he almost wished he wasn't turning twenty-eight again. After so many times, it had lost its thrill.

The opening ceremony of Vanity Fair was anything but quaint. Smoke from smoldering pages choked the air. The world reeked of burnt paper. Jericho stood before the ash pit of Directories that the Vysarians had used to carry out their will. The people had gathered what was left of them behind the Atrium and set the books ablaze without a second thought.

"Why?" he asked the onlookers, but not a soul answered him.

"Is this not history?" He asked them. Again, no one answered.

He turned to them, each of them, and looked them straight in the eye. What would happen now that they were a people who had resorted to burning books?

"I have seen what they do in places when they burn

books, and they don't stop there," Jericho said. His heart sank when, again, no one answered him. Instead, they rebuked his trivial efforts to correct them by tossing more of The Directories into the pile.

His eyes glazed over. He watched as the fire roared and blotted out the sun. Futures full of atrocities and love written on the same page burned before him. He had believed in both and even brought some of them to fruition. He wished now that he had never picked it up. He wished that it never existed, that he had never thought to rewrite it. After all, it was his proximity to the book that had brought him nothing but misfortune. It was the book that had brought him back to Atlas to appear before the Fair, the vainest of ceremonies. Or was it to turn into a trial?

He could only dream of what the films would say about the Vysarian in there and what he would see on the screen about all those sons. The losers. The teachers. The Legionnaires. The brothers, sons, and fathers. The queer boys trying so hard to play straight. They were all his friends. His priest. His lover. His hero and enemy. Witches, beasts, and all. He didn't care. He knew them for who they were, as they knew him for who he truly was.

"So then tell me, Mr. Jaroh, do you mind me calling you that?" Augustus asked.

"Go ahead," Jericho replied.

"Good. Tonight, you continue the tradition of awarding storytelling because you believe it has power in such a broken world. Won't you tell us then what you know, what

you remember, and all the things in between? The films with the largest presence here don't say your name once in the credits. Tell me why that is. With so many rumors and speculation—"

Jericho held up his hand, shocking Augustus to silence. "Because there have been so many rumors and speculation, let me tell you the story. The whole story. According to The Directory, the deaths occurred at the twenty-third hour—the direct result of the youngest son."

Jericho's words echoed across the Imperium for all to hear. The equarians, Earth's nobility, who lined the carpet eagerly waiting to fill empty seats in the Atrium raged at his words. They refused to believe he knew it all. As if a freak of nature knew the whole story. A story that spanned generations. Who was he to know the history of the family that had disemboweled the Earth and changed the fate of the universe forever?

Before the equarians could mob after him, Jericho was ushered into the Atrium. Inside, he shuffled uncomfortably in his seat, recalling all the obnoxious debates that had taken place under the dome. He stopped a young boy who held a paper in his hand as he ran up the staircase. He asked him for a copy and gave him a tip in return. As he flattened it against the air, the publisher caught his eye: The Hegemon. It had been brought from Earth, or perhaps print news had finally found its way to the rings. The headline read: *VANITY AT THE FAIR. VYSARIANS DEAD AT LAST. DIRECTORIES DESTROYED. WHAT NEXT?*

Jericho shook his head. *Dead at last... but was this the*

only way? Could they not have been taught? Aren't all men like the Vysarians at their core? He held the paper up. The young boy recognized him immediately from his photo on the backside.

"You're Mr. Jaroh."

Jericho brought the paper down and shushed the boy. He yelled frantically for his counterparts to join him. Jericho clamped his hand over the boy's mouth, but he continued to mumble through it, so Jericho waited until he stopped. He pulled back in disgust when the boy licked his palm. When he removed his hand, the boy started up again.

"Is it true?" He asked him. "Did you know them?"

"Well, yes."

"All of them?"

"Yes, I knew all of them."

Another boy, most likely his older brother, overheard them and rushed to get answers.

"And were they all evil?" The older brother questioned.

"No. They weren't. At least not in the beginning. They meant well."

"Then what happened?"

"Well, I don't know." Jericho stared off into the distance. He tried to recall all of his lives. The boys were beginning to gather and store up stares from nearby. The two in front of him knew this, and so they continued to edge the Jaroh on until he relented and remembered.

"He was good... at first. The first Vysrian. He had good intentions. He wanted to do good things. I remember him

telling me that.”

“Who?” Asked the younger brother.

“Vysarian.”

“Which one?”

An equarian boy in the crowd with strawberry hair scoffed and spat at the mention of their name. “I heard it was always their plan to kill everyone. Every last one of them. They wanted to destroy everyone who wasn’t like them. I heard they passed the disease down and their disgusting agenda through the generations. If the father couldn’t end the world, then the son would!”

Jericho held up his hand to the boys. “That’s not true. Don’t listen to him,” he said. “I knew them. That was never their intention. It was true they were different but—”

“How so?” Asked the younger boy.

“Why? So you can get the inside scoop? You’ll hear it all once you see it,” Jericho said, extending his arms out to the Atrium.

“What the players created is a lie.” The brother said. “And they’ll make you lie to the whole world to corroborate their truth. They’ll make you tell the world that they were terrible people so that they can blame everything that’s happened on them and say their movie is real.” He pointed to the equarian boy, then the Custodians who surrounded him. They had drawn themselves a small audience.

“They got their history from them, and they’re looking for someone to blame everything on.”

The strawberry boy stood up and pushed the older

brother. "Watch where you point! I'll break that God damn finger. And it ain't lyin if it's the truth!"

"What do you know about truth?" The brother pushed back.

"I know they liked little boys like you," the strawberry boy spat.

"Now, wait a minute." Jericho got in between them and tried to split up their quarrel. "Where did you hear that?" He asked, holding back the angry boy by his shoulders.

"It's in the paper! Can't you read?" The equarian brought up the paper and pointed a finger to a sentence.

Vysarian boys were all hidden homosexuals (see Jericho Jaroh page 4). A misdiagnosed symptom of evil?

Jericho's stomach turned upside down.

"Won't you tell us what really happened?" Asked the younger brother. He wanted to hear his truths from Jericho's lips. "Don't let them make you lie to everyone. Tell us the truth."

"Well," Jericho began. The truth was, he didn't know where to begin. What was true, and what had they filled his head with at that damn clinic? It had been so long now... it all seemed true to him.

"You don't remember, do you?" Asked the strawberry boy.

"No, I do," Jericho commanded. But perhaps he didn't. He had changed sleeves so many times, still he willed himself to remember. "I do. I really do. It's just been a long time. What happened— it wasn't their fault."

"The hell it wasn't. They had a choice!" Said the

strawberry boy.

“They didn’t. They did what they thought was right. Between the Custodians and the men in charge, they did what they could. The Vysarian boys dreamt of a new Imperium, a better *what if*— a whole new universe. All of them. Even without the tools to write down their questions, they knew what life could have been. They knew no one was going to build it for them, so they took matters into their own hands.”

The rest of the crowd filtered into their seats in the Atrium, eagerly awaiting the Fair. Jericho observed the disparities between them. The Custodians were still accustomed to a finer life. Finely tuned bodies that rose and moved at their command. Beautiful synthetic hair, strands as thin as microchips. Skin, still porcelain at first glance, but as strong as platinum to the touch.

A few of the equarians had made it into the spare seats. Although wealthy by Earthly standards, they still wore the rags the Vysarian families and all those in between had dealt them over the years. They looked miserable. Tired. Sullen and sulking. They had suffered the Animus first hand but had lived to tell the tale. After everything that happened, all the lies and torments, the waking night terrors that life had become, it was no surprise that they were jaded and angry. They were tired of superfluous things, yet here they were preparing to subject themselves to another round.

The crowd noticed Jericho’s presence among them. As they quieted themselves, noted that it was time for the Fair

to begin and the Jarohs to be awarded. Jericho left the boys to fight with the equarian and took his place on the stage. He brought out his copy of the book that had foretold their fates for decades now. It was likely the last place in the universe to hold such words. He ran his fingers over the disfigured cover that he had drawn over. He had renamed it *The New Directory: Revised*.

Jericho cleared his throat and placed one hand on top of the cover, the other on its spine. He knew what being in this place and time meant. They had survived the Vysarians, the Animus, and themselves. There was more to this story of humanity than anyone could have foretold. Not even The Directory knew what was next. He began the next great leap by telling the story of where they had come from and how it had all started.

“When I see the word ‘Earth,’ I know many claim it as their own as a title, a privilege, a status, as if God chose them. They are right in this: God chooses, but they are wrong in thinking: only them. God breathes through many begotten sons and daughters. Tonight, we acknowledge our ancestors. Earth might be lost to us, but I vow that we will not allow their stories, their experiences, or their wisdom to fade.”

“We gather here this week to celebrate the power of film and the unending ability of art to mend broken hearts and worlds torn apart by violent, greedy, devious men. I’m here to speak about the character and deeds of those men. While reality can be painful to remember, it is imperative to record it, lest history repeat itself and we make the same

mistakes.”

“I created the Fair to remind everyone of the vanity of man. I see by your gowns and suits that you’ve all leaned into this without me even having to ask. We’ve gotten so bored that we all made each other into celebrities. To counteract such a homogenous culture of complicity, I hope to deliver the Jarohs to the most deserving. It will be a reminder to everyone that we should reward the truth instead of the obscene. There is always something to be gained by being honest, while the pomp and circ will always wither and rot. Throughout the Fair, I will be the judge and jury for the various retellings and visual chapters that you’ve crafted about the truth, all inspired by the lives of the Vysarian boys.”

“While we are here to celebrate a plethora of films and the resurgence of the art form, I do believe that it’s in the best interest of Vanity Fair, the nominees, the families, and the survivors gathered here today to remember where it all started so that we might move on from this moment.”

“In a small town in the middle of the Yosemite Valley, there was a teacher. A young boy on the precipice of becoming a man. He took on a host of identities: educator, partner, legionnaire, Babylonian, dragon, all in a vain attempt to find himself. He found that all was vanity. He lost himself, riddled with pondering what it meant to be human. He spent his days wondering if people cared for those like him. He spent his nights hoping that one day, powerful men might find it within themselves to love poor boys. He wandered the Earth looking for leaders and

lovers.

Jericho Jaroh looked up into the blinding lights of the house. With a quivering grin, a stone heart, and the knowledge that he was about to damn himself to eternity, he spoke to no one in particular. "Could you please roll the first film?"